



Great barracuda

Sphyræna barracuda



This long, torpedo-shaped fish hunts alone or in packs. By day, great barracudas gather in large schools that patrol the periphery of warm-water coral reefs, opting for safety in numbers over the chance to make a kill. By night, the school fragments, and lone adults glide over the reef to ambush fish at close quarters, while juveniles maraud in smaller groups that harass schools of fish.

Toothy jaw

The great barracuda's long, streamlined body, along with short, stiff fins that provide stability, make it capable of many modes of swimming, from a steady cruise to a lightning fast surge—all powered by the large, triangular tail fins. The barracuda's jaw has a distinctive underbite with the lower jaw poking out in front of its head. This gives the fish a wide gape and exposes needlelike teeth, which are embedded in

the jaw bones and the roof of the mouth. The long, toothy jaw is ideal for gripping small, struggling fish, but is also capable of delivering a powerful bite that can cut through larger prey. Occasionally, a lone barracuda will give a diver a nasty bite if it mistakes a hand or shiny diving watch for a small, silvery fish.

Great barracudas spawn in open water, and the eggs are left to drift unattended. The fry shelter in estuaries until they are 3 in (8cm) long, then they head out to sea.

The flesh of large barracudas contains lethal toxins

- ↔ Up to 7 ft (2m)
- ⚖ Up to 110 lb (50 kg)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🐟 Fish
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Tropical and subtropical waters worldwide